

EFL learners' critical multimodal reflections on the politics of English

Shin-ying Huang

National Taiwan University

Funding information

Ministry of Science and Technology, Taiwan,
Grant/Award Number: MOST 103-2410-H-002-233

There has been increasing effort in English as a second and foreign language education to incorporate a critical perspective, either highlighting the politics of English in terms of native-speakerism, standards, varieties, and accents or aiming to develop learners' critical awareness of issues pertaining to race, class, and gender. There has also been growing interest in the potential of multimodal pedagogies for language learning. However, very little research has engaged language learners in exploring the politics of English in the context of race, class, and gender power relations from a multimodal perspective. Thus, this study investigates how learners of English as a foreign language, through a multimodal approach, reflect on the politics of English as relating to race, class, and/or gender. Examination of learners' multimodal ensembles found that thinking multimodally rather than only linguistically may contribute to the consideration of an issue from a less dominant point of view, leading to critical reflection. In addition, multimodal ensembles may allow learners to express their critical engagement with an issue in ways that the linguistic mode might restrict. The pedagogical implications of these findings are discussed using examples from students' multimodal projects, and possible directions for future research are proposed.

1 | INTRODUCTION

Since the field of TESOL took a critical turn in the 1990s (Kumaravadivelu, 2006a), language researchers and educators have “critiqued inequalities and injustices in our society and envisioned areas for social change” (Kubota & Miller, 2017, p. 129). A critical perspective in language scholarship involves considerations of power relations in language practices, that is, language “as a key means of mobilizing meaning to sustain or contest relations of domination in society” (Janks, 2008, p. 183). Critical studies in TESOL have largely taken two directions.

First, a large body of work has examined the dominance of English and its impact, resulting in concerns about how language learners relate to the global and international nature of English (e.g., Erling, 2007; Matsuda, 2003), understand world Englishes (e.g., Ates, Eslami, & Wright, 2015; Yoshikawa, 2005), and respond to English as a lingua franca (e.g., Jenkins, 2007; Mauranten, 2012). Classroom efforts aimed at promoting English as a second/foreign language (ESL/EFL) learners’ critical awareness of English hegemony have often pertained to native-speakerism, standards, varieties, and accents (e.g., Chan, 2016; Chang, 2014). However, these studies that address how language learners contest the dominance of English do not at the same time examine its impact on race, class, gender, and other identity categories, even though linguistic imperialism is inevitably bound up in relations of race, class, and gender. Motha’s (2006a) work highlights the intersecting influences of “linguistic and racial hierarchies” (p. 76), but she examines the resulting identities of native-English-speaking teachers of English as a second language (ESL) rather than the learners (see also Motha, 2006b). Chun’s (2016) work examines racialized discourses in language classrooms, but the emphasis is on the course instructor more than on the learners.

Second, issues of race, class, and gender have received much attention in second and foreign language studies. However, these efforts do not always involve classroom research and seldom take into account of the politics of English. For example, there have been concerns regarding the influence of socioeconomic class on English learning and teaching (e.g., Kanno & Vandrick, 2014; Vandrick, 2011), but these remain scholarly considerations rather than classroom work that engages learners in critical reflection. In contrast, race and gender have been critically explored in language classrooms (e.g., for race: Hammond, 2006; Taylor, 2006; for gender: Morgan, 1997; C. Nelson, 2004), but in these efforts English served as the means of exploration rather than simultaneously the content of examination.

In other words, there have been very few studies that involved language learners, particularly English as a foreign language (EFL) learners, in discussions of the politics of English in relation to race, class, and gender, and even fewer that explored the topic through a multimodal approach. In Chun’s (2012) study of a course in which English and globalization were examined in the context of multimodal YouTube videos, the focus of classroom discussions was more on deconstructing the linguistic choices and content than on the visual and aural aspects of how globalization was represented multimodally, although a multimodal analysis was supplemented by Chun. Thus, the present study investigates the ways in which EFL learners, through a multimodal approach, reflect on the politics of English as relating to race, class, and/or gender. In the effort, the study also explores the implications of multimodal pedagogy for the development of critical literacy, i.e., a critical perspective toward language and literacy practices.

2 | MULTIMODAL PEDAGOGIES AND THE CRITICAL PERSPECTIVE

Despite increasing incorporation of multimodal pedagogies in English language classrooms in ESL and EFL contexts (e.g., Early, Kendrick, & Potts, 2015; Hafner, 2014; M. E. Nelson, 2008; Shin &

Cimasko, 2008), very little attention has been paid to the critical dimension of multimodality. One exception is Huang's (2015) research, in which English learners critiqued movies in a multimodal format, demonstrating that what is shown can sometimes say more than what is told in terms of a critical perspective. Although not pertaining to TESOL, the connection between multimodality and criticality was also examined in Stein's (2008) seminal study of African youths' storytelling, which reveals that the visual mode enabled their expression of the private and unsayable in ways that the linguistic mode did not, suggesting that multimodality can contribute to the expression of critical awareness. Curwood and Gibbons (2010) also show how multiple modes were employed by a student to create a counternarrative that resisted oppressive discourses about race and sexual orientation in his school community and in which he affirmed his identities.

Albers (2011), also aiming to address the critical dimension of multimodality, did not have such optimistic findings in her study. In her preservice teachers' multimodal texts, produced in response to an assignment that required them to present their understanding of a self-chosen social issue, Albers found that her students were largely influenced by common assumptions about those issues rather than being critical of how the issues are frequently represented. In other words, the fact these preservice teachers composed multimodally did not seem to bear much relevance for a critical perspective, a finding similar to Schmier's (2013) study, which appeared in a volume discussing critical digital literacies. This work examined a multimodal video created by eighth-grade students that discussed the issue of abortion. It was found that, perhaps because the instructor did not emphasize an explicit critical perspective, multimodality afforded limited potential in promoting the students' resistance to dominant discourses. However, the works of Albers and Schmier differ from those of Curwood and Gibbons (2010), Huang (2015), and Stein (2008) in that in these latter studies the students were not asked to address social issues in their multimodal ensembles, which can be argued to be a higher order academic task that is more challenging. Thus, the present research is another attempt to explore how learners make use of multiple semiotic resources to discuss a social issue, in this case, the politics of English as relating to race, class, and/or gender.

This study draws from a critical multimodality framework, which is, the understanding that "different semiotic material[s] have affordances that can be deployed for ideological purposes" (Machin, Caldas-Coulthard, & Milani, 2016, p. 306). By extension, critical multimodal literacy is the ability to (1) identify the ideological purposes in multimodal representations and (2) orchestrate multiple semiotic resources to speak back to inequitable social structures and practices. This study addresses the second aspect of critical multimodal literacy.

3 | METHODS

The study takes a qualitative interpretive approach (Denzin & Lincoln, 2011; Richards, 2003) to understanding students' practices. The context of the study was a year-long general English course offered to undergraduate students in a university in Taiwan. Students in Taiwan study English as a school subject as part of their compulsory education, although most students start learning English even before they begin primary education, often in private preschools that offer partial or complete English immersion. Most of the 28 students (14 females and 14 males) enrolled in the course were from the College of Bio-Resources and Agriculture, and were freshmen of around 18 years of age at the time of the study. There were also a sophomore engineering major, a senior engineering major, a junior Japanese major, and a senior majoring in pharmacology. A faculty member at the university, I was both the instructor of the course and the researcher of this study.

3.1 | The study and its pedagogical context

The course was designed with an emphasis on English language learning as sociocultural and ideological. Throughout the two semesters of the academic year, the class discussed print and multimedia texts for the purpose of understanding language as existing not in a vacuum but always in the context of race, class, and gender and their resulting power relations.

To begin with, the relationship between language and culture was considered using both print and multimedia texts, including Shen's (1989) *The Classroom and the Wider Culture: Identity as a Key to Learning English Composition*, Tan's (1990) *Mother Tongue*, and Season 2 Episode 5 of the TV show *The Middle* (Hunter, Hunter, & Lazarus, 2010), in which the main characters host a foreign exchange student from Japan. It was also important to discuss power relations in issues concerning race, class, and gender, a concept less emphasized in EFL classrooms and seldom considered in EFL courses in Taiwan. Following Huang (2015), the intersection of race, class, and gender was examined through three movies: *Romeo Must Die* (Silver, Van Wyck, & Bartkowiak, 2000), *Maid in Manhattan* (Goldsmith-Thomas, Schiff, Schindler, & Wang, 2002), and *The Help* (Columbus, Barnathan, Green, & Taylor, 2011). Finally, the first episode of the TV show *Fresh Off the Boat* (Khan & Shelton, 2015) and J. Yang's (2015) *Los Angeles Times* article about this show were discussed. Both these texts are reflections of experiences within particular situations of race, class, and gender. The juxtaposition of these two texts also allowed the consideration of the affordances of different semiotic resources in representation.

A unifying goal in the discussion of all these print and multimedia texts was the exploration of power relations that undergird issues of race, class, gender, and their intersection with language and culture as expressed through different semiotic resources, which reflects the critical multimodal perspective that frames this study. At the end of the year, the students were asked to submit a multimodal ensemble in which they considered English and its relations to issues of race, class, and/or gender. Specifically, the students were asked to address the following points:

- What are some ways English is intertwined with race/class/gender that you have noticed?
- Give some examples that you find in all aspects of your daily life. Giving examples does not mean copying and pasting videos or webpages or pictures or photographs, but show the examples through your own multimodal composing.

3.2 | Data sources and analysis

This study draws from the students' multimodal ensembles as the source of data. Much has been discussed about the transcription and analysis of multimodal videos (e.g., Baldry & Thibault, 2006) due to concerns about the capacity of textual forms to represent embodied communicative practices (Mavers, 2012), especially those captured through techniques aimed at particular artistic expressions (Rose, 2000). However, students' multimodal texts are often different from commercial audiovisual materials in their strategies of remix (Hafner, 2015; Knobel & Lankshear, 2008), best described as involving a process which "re-mixed a variety of audio, visual, and written texts retrieved mainly by going to the [various] Internet sites that they referenced in their presentation" (Mahiri, 2006, p. 58).

My students' ensembles employed remix strategies, that is, including visuals and soundtrack along with their own written text. Based on the nature of these ensembles, the frame was decided to be the most logical unit of analysis. The transcription of the students' multimodal ensembles involved breaking down the ensembles not only into individual frames but also subdividing the frames into their sequenced elemental accumulation in order to see how the students constructed each frame, through which can be

gleaned their thought process pertaining to particular content. This approach allowed the simultaneous focus on content (i.e., what the students thought about the topic) and multimodality (i.e., how the students orchestrated multiple modes to get across their message) during analysis of the ensembles.

For example (see Figure 1), such an approach allowed the fine-tuned understanding that differences in the spatial organization of the “components” of learning in the first few frames of Cheng-Chu's ensemble (i.e., as a diagonal progression in cells 1 to 4, as a standalone in cell 5, and as overlapping in cells 6 to 10) not only represent the different functions of learning—formal schooling (in cells 1 to 4) versus private institutes (in cell 5), but also the different purposes of learning—for education (in cells 1 to 5) or for recreation (in cells 6 to 10). In addition, the visual representation of diagonal progression versus overlapping images indicates whether the learning took place in stages or coexisted simultaneously.

For the purposes of this article, two students’ multimodal ensembles have been selected for detailed discussion. These are the works of Hsin-Erh Lung (henceforth Hsin-Erh) and Cheng-Chu Hu (henceforth Cheng-Chu), both female freshman students from the College of Bio-Resources and Agriculture. They consented to the discussion of their ensembles in this article and opted to be identified by their names rather than pseudonyms. The selection of these two ensembles was not primarily due to their representativeness of the range of student works, but because they show different ways in which semiotic resources were effectively orchestrated to fulfill particular communicative goals and demonstrate the potential of critical reflection through multimodal means. The ensembles (please see <https://vimeo.com/234080299> for Hsin-Erh's and <https://vimeo.com/234081216> for Cheng-Chu's) should be viewed in relation to the discussion of the findings. (The nine figures are included in order

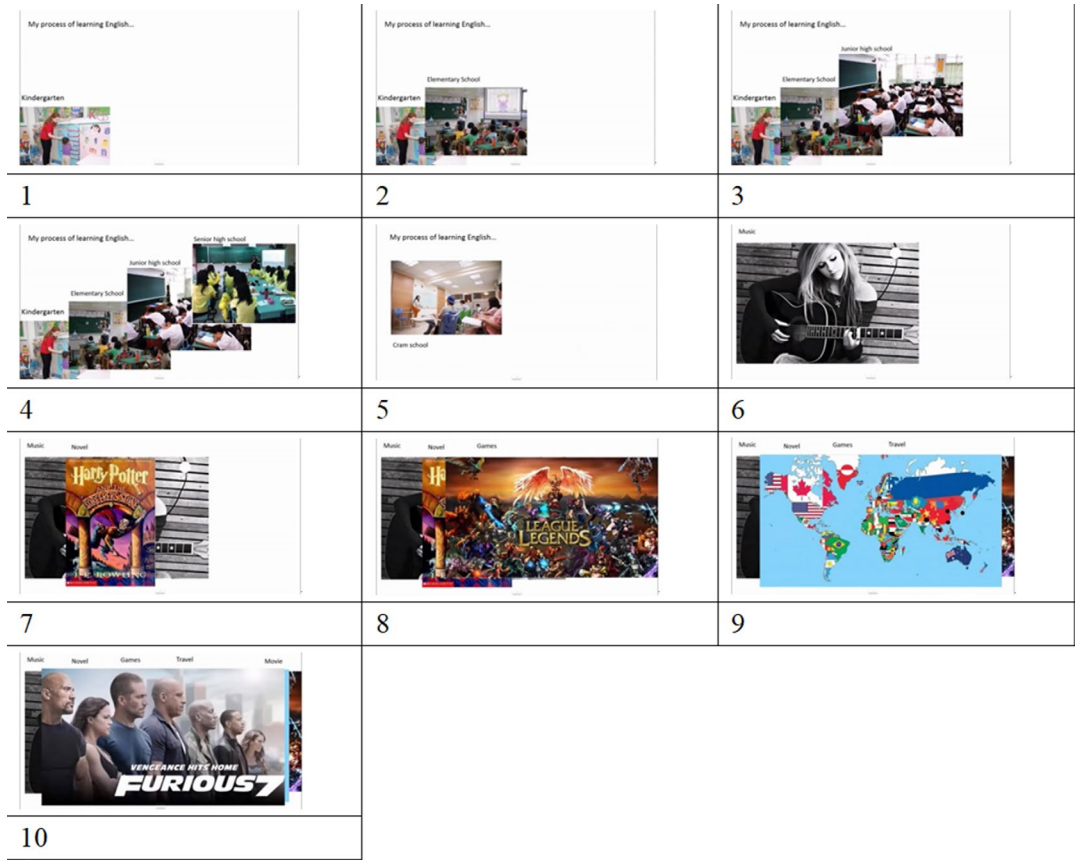


FIGURE 1 Transcribing frames and their sequenced elemental accumulation

to illustrate aspects of the discussion, and therefore, do not show details of the students' ensembles. To see particular aspects of the ensembles, please view the students' works following the URLs provided.)

Before moving on, it is important to acknowledge that critical (multimodal) discourse analysis has been criticized for not taking into account the meanings intended by text producers (Mayr & Machin, 2012). However, the meanings intended by text producers have received much attention when multimodal ensembles have been produced by EFL learners (e.g., M. E. Nelson, 2008; M. E. Nelson & Johnson, 2014; Y. F. Yang, 2012). Ensembles created by EFL learners have less commonly been examined as texts in their own right—deserving of analysis in and of themselves without the necessary supplementary explanations of their producers, such as the ensemble discussed in Hull and Nelson (2005). Thus, this study focuses on the messages communicated multimodally in the texts themselves.

4 | REPRESENTING “THE UNSAYABLE” THROUGH VISUALS

Hsin-Erh's ensemble is titled “English and Internet.” The ensemble first addresses how the internet transmits the “system of values” of English speakers and then provides examples of how a simple Google search immerses one in the race, class, and gender ideologies of the English-speaking world.

In the beginning, the ensemble demonstrates that power relations abound where the internet is concerned. Figure 2 shows that even though the internet is used globally, it is dominated by particular groups of people, which are represented by emojis. Only two sets of emojis are linguistically identified, including for one set, “North America, Europe, Australia,” and for the other set, “China, Japan.” The importance of these two sets of emojis, in addition to being underscored by the linguistic mode, is highlighted by the visual mode, through arrows conspicuously thicker than the other arrows, each emanating from an image of a laptop computer placed behind each set of emojis, all pointing to the image of a globe, placed in a central position above the five sets of emojis. This shows that different groups of people (ethnically and nationally) around the world have different amounts of input to the global information system through the internet, with China and Japan as well as North America,



FIGURE 2 Different peoples contributing different amounts of information

Europe, and Australia being the predominant contributors. Although this image clearly shows that people from the aforementioned regions/nation-states contribute the most information to the world, the linguistic summary in a later frame states that these people “hav[e] more chance of providing and receiving information through the internet.” The discrepancy between what is shown and what is told is that the visual representation is not concerned at all with *receiving* information but focuses on who *provides* more information.

Another example of such discrepancy occurs in the next frame that considers the global dominance of English and related power dynamics. Figure 3 shows that information from the aforementioned two sets of emojis are not equally disseminated. Information that is provided “with English” is distributed to people all over the world, that is, five sets of emojis, whereas information that is distributed “with Chinese, Japanese” only reaches the same set of emoji that provided the information. Thus, the visual representation shows that information provided (connoted by the arrow emanating from the two emojis in the top left corner) in English is spread to (connoted by the arrow emanating from the laptop and directed at the emojis in the top right corner) people all over the world, whereas information provided in Chinese/Japanese is spread only to Chinese/Japanese speakers. However, the linguistic summary in the following frame states that “English is the world language. If people want to get the information from the world, they will use English.” Again, what is visually represented is not the same as what is then linguistically summarized. Specifically, Figure 3 discusses English and the internet from the perspective of the information provider, that is, what happens to the information each set of emojis provides, whereas the ensuing linguistic summary considers the issue from the perspective of getting information. Furthermore, Figure 3 shows the power of English over other languages such as Chinese and Japanese. The linguistic summary, however, has no such implications of power relations, but rather, suggests a practical focus about people using English to obtain information.

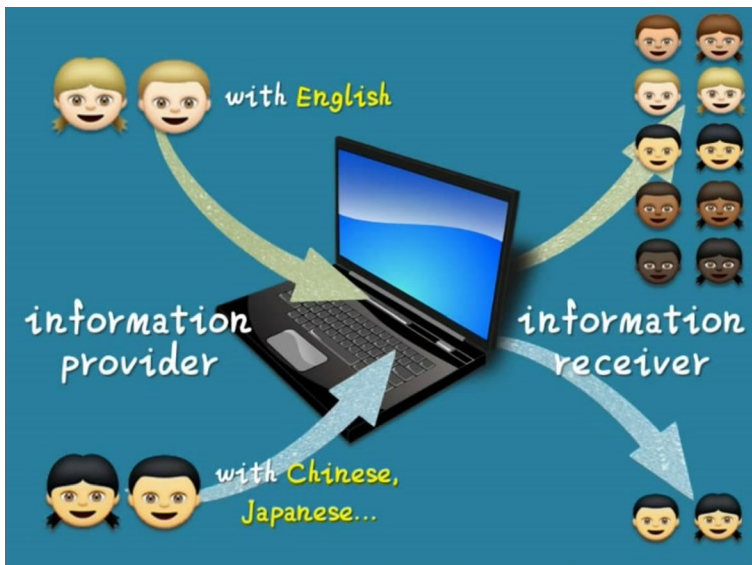


FIGURE 3 Information providers and receivers

A third example of such discrepancy occurs in the next frame (Figure 4), which highlights the dominant status of English and its speakers on the internet. Through the visual representation of a filter, the internet is shown as filtering out languages other than English. Whereas the visual representation underscores whose language/information can survive the filtering of the internet, the linguistic summary emphasizes information reception: “Information from them could be received easily if the keywords are English.” The repeated emphasis on “receiving” information in the linguistic summaries across these

examples reflects the discourse in Taiwan that understands access to information as one of the main rationales for learning English. However, although the linguistic expression reflects such discourse, the visual representation clearly shows another layer of thinking: that of the dominance of English on the internet.

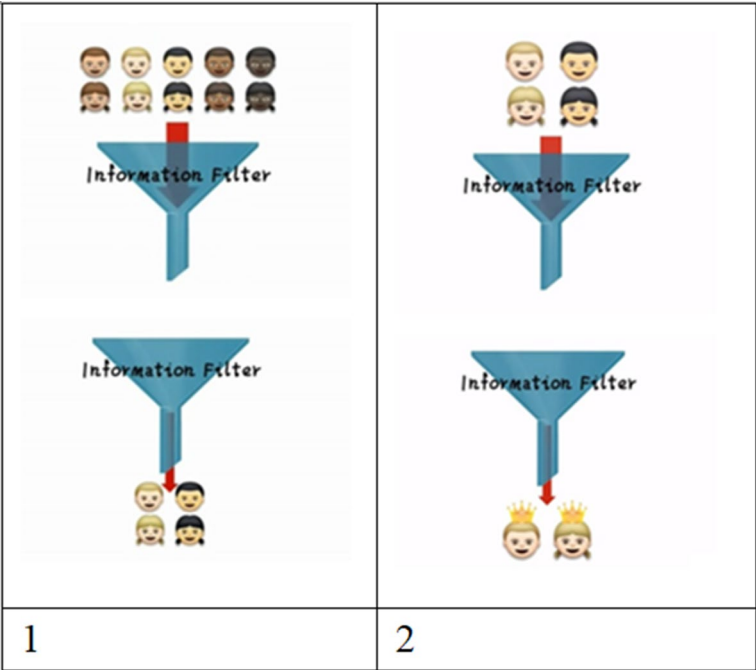


FIGURE 4 Information filter

The next frame then explains the consequence of English speakers’ dominance on the internet. In Figure 5, even without the linguistic support offered by the words “system of values,” the speech bubbles emanating from the emojis at the top of the frame clearly connote the worldviews of

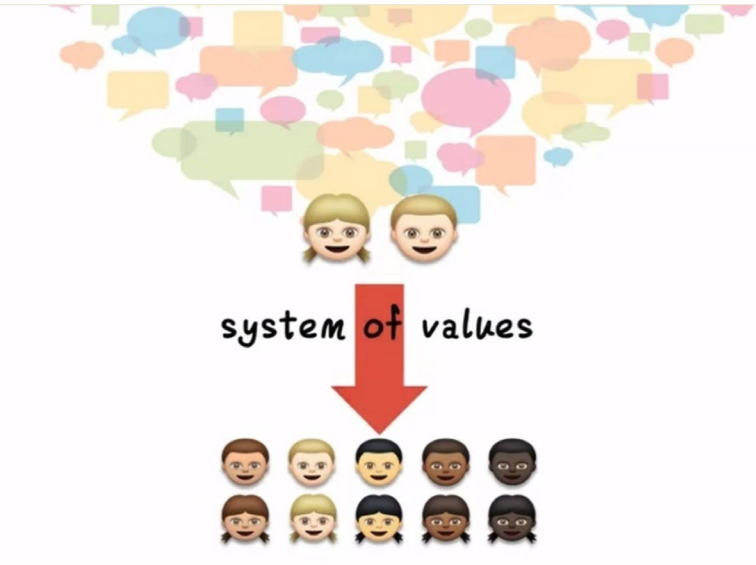


FIGURE 5 Transmission of worldviews

English-speaking people. This “system of values” is transmitted, connoted through the visual of the downward-moving arrow, to people around the world.

As for what the “system of values” is, a visual analysis is shown in the next part of the ensemble by representing the process of Google image searches. The Taiwan version of Google was used, but the search words entered were in English, including “men,” “women,” “rich people,” “poor people,” “black people,” “handsome,” and “beauty,” in the order listed. These seven terms encompass the categories of gender, class, and race. This visual analysis demonstrates that the “system of values” that is transmitted to the world in English through the internet encompasses racialized gender and class ideologies, and that race can also be divided along class lines, with the White being rich and the non-White being poor. Hsin-Erh then came to this conclusion: “Strictly speaking, the information is controlled. And the system of values is transmitted with the world language—English, and the internet.” Thus, what is visually demonstrated—the Internet as not only a conduit for the spread of English and its worldviews, but more importantly as exacerbating intersecting systems of inequality along the lines of race, class, and gender—is essentially the point Kumaravadivelu (2006b) makes in his discussion of the dangerous liaison among globalization, empire, and TESOL. He characterizes the internet as a significant force shaping “the global flows of interested knowledge, hegemonic power, and cultural capital” (p. 1) through English as a result of its status as a global language.

In this ensemble, the visual representations reveal critical reflections that were not present in the linguistic summaries except in the conclusion that came after the visual analysis. This points to what Stein (2008) discussed as “the limits of language” (p. 75). However, unlike for the young women in Stein's study whose stories were “unsayable” because saying them would have resulted in further harm or abuse, for Hsin-Erh, the hegemony of English was “unsayable” because people in Taiwan rarely consider this aspect of English; that is, it is seldom a part of the discourse in her sociopolitical context, and therefore it is rarely “said.” Thus, as a result of the dominance of particular discourses (i.e., English as providing access to information) expressed through language, it may be difficult to use language to “say” otherwise, because thinking linguistically may lead to the same thoughts. However, thinking in another mode, visually, may have allowed the emergence of another direction of thinking, that is, the power of English on the internet and its consequences.

That a different mode (e.g., visual) could lead to another direction of thinking in an area that has been dominated by ideas expressed in one mode (e.g., linguistic) can perhaps find resonance in the experiences of Friedrich Nietzsche, the 19th-century German philosopher who, as a result of using a typewriter rather than writing on paper, observed that “our writing equipment takes part in the forming of our thoughts” (Carr, 2008, ¶13). Thus, if even the tool could impact the content, why not the mode through which the content is communicated? Although more research is necessary to make any definitive claims about the potential of different modes to contribute to different orientations of thinking, the findings certainly point to this possibility.

5 | DEMONSTRATING CRITICAL ENGAGEMENT THROUGH PLACEMENT PATH

Cheng-Chu's ensemble is titled “English Words, English Culture.” The first part chronicles her learning of English and what she did not take into account in the process of over a decade of learning. The second part then presents her findings regarding the discriminatory nature of some vocabularies pertaining to race and gender, which I examine in detail in what follows.

Four racial slurs are discussed in this ensemble: *Chink*, *Jap*, *Vinegar*, and *Negro*. The manner of the visual representation reflects the language learning perspective this ensemble follows. Take *Chink*,

for example, the first word discussed (see Figure 6). The source and origin of the word are presented before the word's meaning and usage (e.g. “chink in the armor,” a phrase an ESPN sportscaster used in 2012 to criticize Chinese American NBA player Jeremy Lin's performance). The consequence of using the word for the employees of ESPN who were involved is also shown (cell 7), all part of Cheng-Chu's learning of the word *Chink*.

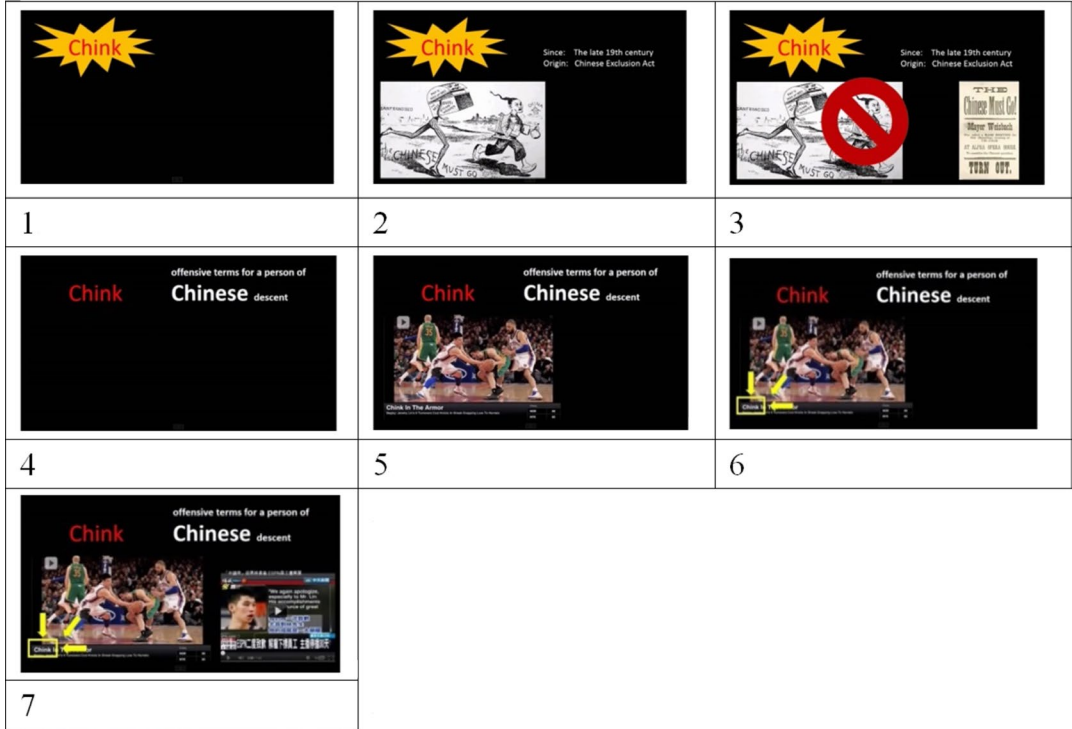


FIGURE 6 Discussion of the word *Chink*

The word and concept of *Negro* was also examined in depth. Figure 7 (cells 1–3) refers to an incident in 2012 when NBC “showed an advert of a monkey competing in gymnastics shortly pictured after African American Gabby Douglas won the gold medal” (“NBC Forced to Apologize,” 2012). This incident is visually represented with an image of Douglas above a screenshot of NBC's commercial, showing NBC's presentation of Douglas leading to the commercial featuring a monkey (see Figure 7 cell 3). What is curious about this frame is that it does not adhere to the left-to-right placement path which this ensemble mostly follows.

I use the phrase *placement path* following what Kress (2003) describes as reading path, i.e., that English is read from left to right, resulting in a left-to-right reading path. Reading paths can also exist in images through spatial positioning of elements, as Kress explains of still images. However, this ensemble is a moving image; the reading path structured into the ensemble is through placement path, which refers to the order and position in which elements in the ensemble are placed. The left-to-right placement path in this ensemble reflects how English is written and read. (More accurately, this ensemble follows a top-to-bottom and left-to-right placement path, for the most part. The following discussion addresses the few exceptions to the left-to-right placement path and the meanings they convey.)

This is the only frame (Figure 7 cells 1–3) in the discussion of words related to race that makes use of the right-to-left placement path, suggesting that the choice is “not arbitrary but motivated” (Stein, 2008, p. 76). In this frame, the two main elements are placed first on the right and then on the left. What is placed first, on the right, is the historical signs of segregation denoting events before the mid-1960s (Figure 7 cell 2). What is placed second, on the left, is the more current event that occurred in 2012 (Figure 7 cell 3). Compare this to the previous frames (Figure 6) and the next frame (Figure 7 cells 4–6), in which visuals of events that occurred earlier are placed on the left and visuals of events that came afterward are placed on the right. Thus, in this frame, the placement path is going backward. As Kress (2003) points out, “in a visual representation the placement of elements in the space of representation ... [has] meaning” in that “whatever relations are to be represented about the world have inevitably to be presented as spatial relations between the depicted elements of an image” (p. 2). The backward directionality in this frame shows that what is discussed is a retrogression rather than a progression in terms of African American rights. In other words, comparing an African American to a monkey is something that did happen in the past but should not have occurred in 2012. Hence, through not only spatial relations of elements (i.e., the historical signs placed on the right) but also placement path that suggests a backward directionality (i.e., placing elements first on the right and then on the left), Cheng-Chu demonstrated her critical engagement with NBC's treatment of Douglas.

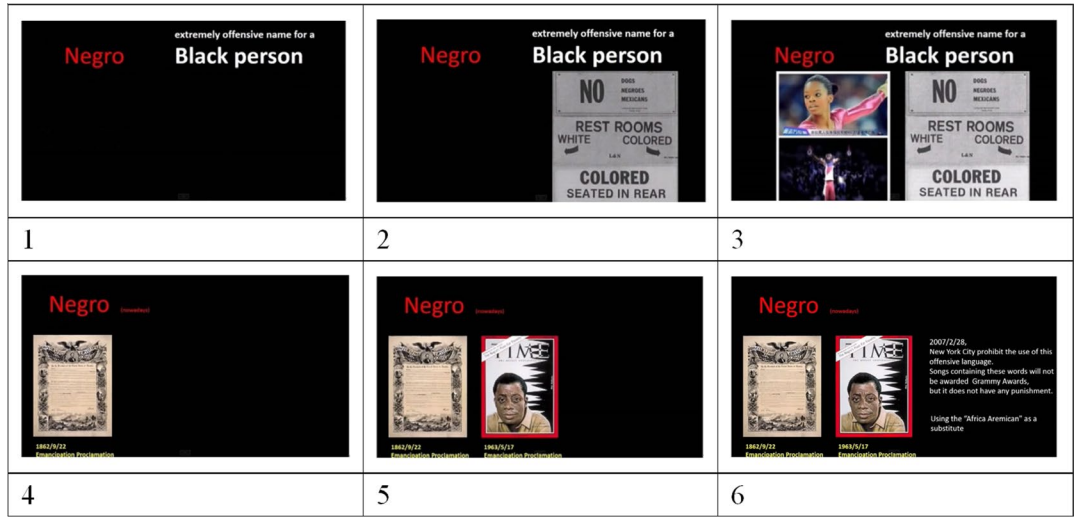


FIGURE 7 Discussion of the word *Negro*

In the second part of the ensemble, the implications of morphologically gender-neutral but socio-logically gender-biased words such as *feisty*, *ambitious*, and *emotional* are examined. The presentation again follows the vocabulary-learning thematic formula, showing the meaning and then the gendered implications of the words followed by examples of gender bias inherent in how the words are often used. In this discussion, the main elements (Figure 8 cells 1–6) are also placed following a right-to-left path. What is placed first, on the right, are photos/quotes of the celebrity women who discuss these words (for *feisty* and *ambitious*). Placed second, on the left, is the source of information—the web pages from which information was found about each of these three words. For *emotional*, placed first on the right are three images likely produced to ridicule women's emotions, particularly the top two, as women who “dar[e]” to show rage are generally more unacceptable than women who show sorrow.

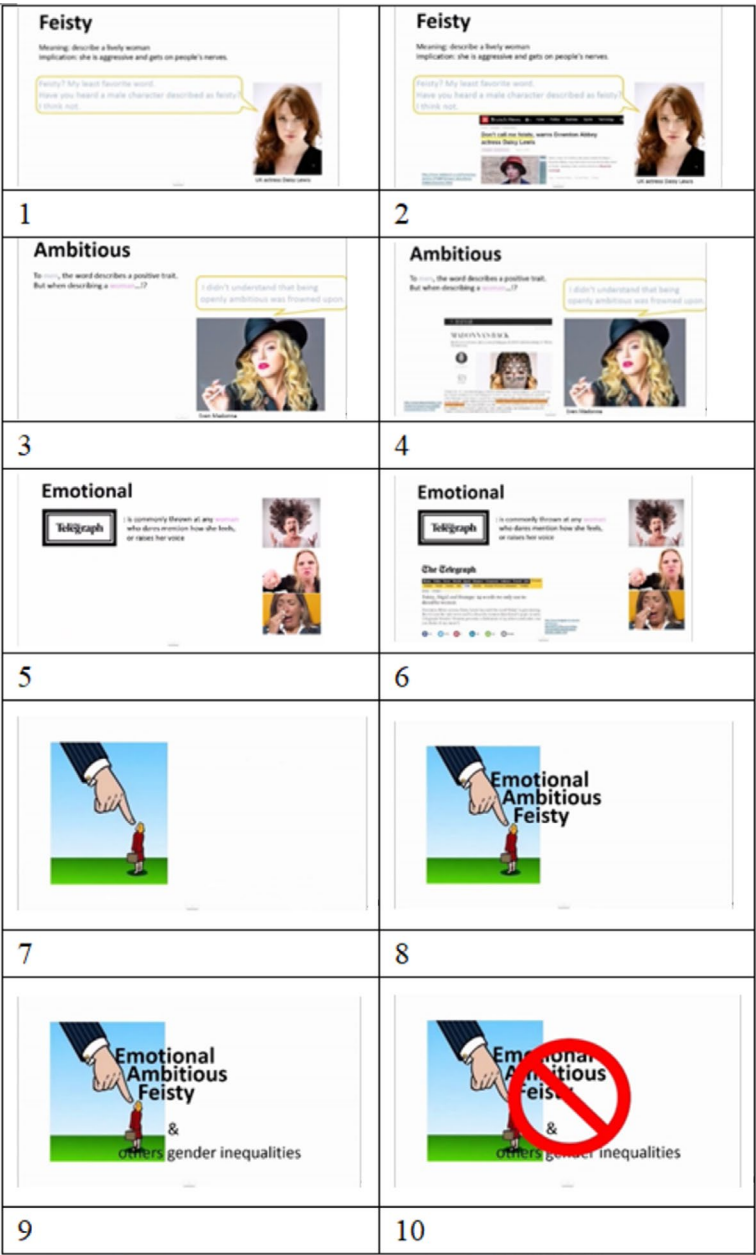


FIGURE 8 Discussion of *feisty*, *ambitious*, and *emotional*

The ensuing frame that sums up the discussion (Figure 8 cells 7–10) reverts back to the usual left-to-right placement path, which is also the case for the frames that came before the examination of these three words in the section of the ensemble that discusses gender.

The elements in these frames are different from the frame that discusses Douglas (Figure 7 cells 1–3) in that both Douglas's Olympic win and segregation are timebound, that is, one occurred in 2012 and the other prior to the mid-1960s. In other words, the time period in which these two elements occurred is the focus of the frame. By contrast, in the frames discussing

gender-related words, the right-to-left placement path does not relate to events that occur at different times.

In exploring the message communicated through this right-to-left placement path, it might be useful to consider any differences if the two main elements in these three frames were placed following a left-to-right placement path. (See Figure 9 for my own rendering of a left-to-right placement path using *ambitious* as an example.) Placing the source web page first, on the left, and then placing, on the right, the photo/quote of the celebrity discussed in the source web page would seem normal and logical. In other words, this would be a conventional placement path through which no particular element stands out, neither the source web page nor the photo/quote. In such a case, even though the photo and accompanying quote would still be the focus of information, because they are placed on the right, according to Kress and van Leeuwen's (2006) visual grammar of information value, it would not have received the dual emphasis it did in the ensemble, that is, not only placed on the right but placed there first. This placement path underscores what the women themselves feel about being described by words such as *feisty* and *ambitious*. For *emotional*, no celebrity photo/quote is offered; instead, there are three images of women with exaggerated expressions who likely would have been described as *emotional*. No celebrity quote is necessary because it is not difficult to understand women being against such portrayals as shown in the images, which obviously deride women's emotions. Thus, through the right-to-left placement path, the ensemble effectively highlights the importance of foregrounding women's views on how they feel about some of the words that are often used to describe them, successfully demonstrating Cheng-Chu's critical engagement of gender ideologies in the English language.

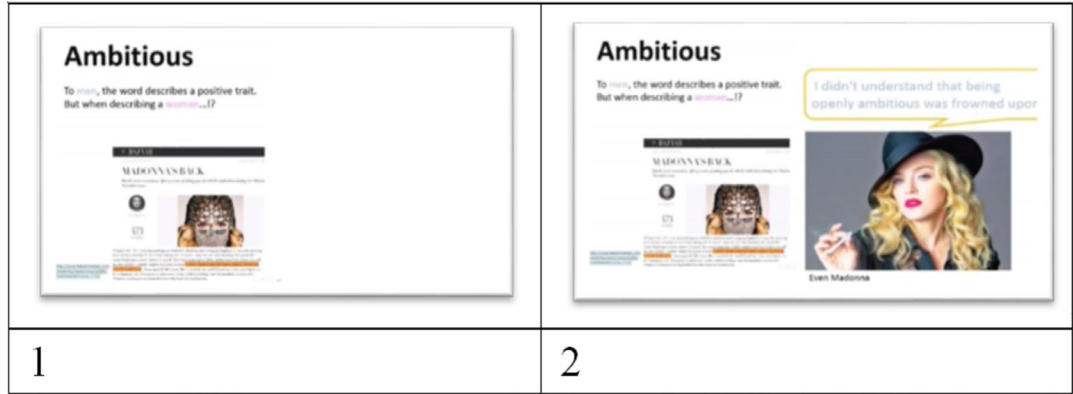


FIGURE 9 My own rendering of a left-to-right placement path

At the end of the ensemble, Cheng-Chu provided a linguistic summary: “There are many vocabularies we use in daily life [that] contain the meaning of race/gender discrimination. We are accustomed to use it without awareness but actually that may be impolite to others. That is how English culture influences us.” This linguistic summary, although expressing her understanding of the discriminatory connotations of certain words and the possible consequences of their usage, does not reflect the layers of meaning demonstrated in the visual representation, which exemplifies her emerging understanding of racism as institutional, i.e., a constitutional and legal matter (see Figure 7 cells 4–6) rather than as only a personal and individual matter, and gender as not only a morphological issue (both in English and also in Chinese) but also as a matter of politics (e.g., morphologically gender-neutral words with ideological connotations when used to describe women). In other words, her visual representation shows that the use of these words is not only a matter of being “impolite to others” but is a reflection

of power relations and ideology, the awareness of which is what Lewis and Ketter (2004) define as “critical engagement” (p. 139). It is very likely that Cheng-Chu lacked the English ability to express her sophisticated understanding through the linguistic mode due to English being a foreign language to her, even though she is an advanced learner by my assessment as the course instructor. However, she was able to effectively express her critical reflections visually through the motivated design of placement path. Thus, the affordances of different modes for the development and expression of critical literacy can be viewed as a continuum, which should be considered in relation to pedagogical goals. This will be discussed in more detail in the next section.

6 | IMPLICATIONS FOR RESEARCH AND PRACTICE

This article examined the ways in which EFL learners, through a multimodal approach, reflect on the politics of English as relating to race, class, and/or gender. In the first instance, the findings show that the dominant linguistic mode perhaps led to the dominant way of thinking about English and the world. In contrast, the multimodal ensemble may have enabled Hsin-Erh to ruminate and examine the topic from another direction, leading to critical reflection. In the second example, the findings demonstrate that multimodality perhaps allowed Cheng-Chu to express her critical engagement with issues of race and gender in ways that the linguistic mode may have restricted.

Although the results of this research point to the potential of multimodal pedagogies to support the development of critical a perspective, how best to employ the affordances of multimodality for criticality has not yet been systematically examined. Future research should investigate the types of multimodal practices that contribute to critical literacy. A possible direction might be to follow up on the discussion started in an earlier section of this article that addressed multimodal pedagogies and the critical perspective with a literature review study that investigates the different ways critical multimodality has been conceptualized and implemented and the impact on learners’ critical literacy. Another area that has received little attention has been the examination of modal choices and their orchestration for the expression of a critical perspective (Albers, 2014). Although this was the focus of the present study, the multimodal ensembles discussed in this article do not make full use of the range of digital technologies currently available. Therefore, future research should also explore the potential for different types and uses of technology in multimodal pedagogy to contribute to critical literacy.

Pedagogically, the students’ multimodal ensembles could also serve to extend their exploration of the politics of different media and the ideological affordances of modes. For example, in Hsin-Erh’s ensemble, the visual analysis she conducted through keyword searches in Google Images showed not only English speakers’ worldview of race, class, and gender, but also the politics of popular media discourses. Specifically, although an image search of the keyword *men* yielded the result of predominantly White men, those images are often of a particular type of White men—muscled White men displaying their bodies—which is the preferred portrayal of men in English-language popular culture rather than how English speakers in general think about White men. Similarly, although an image search of *rich people* yielded the result of predominantly White men, the circumstances in which these rich White men appear in the images also reflect preferred media portrayals. Thus, possible follow-up work for Hsin-Erh would be further analysis of the images for their sources of bias. In Cheng-Chu’s ensemble, the juxtaposition of the consequences of using the word *Chink* to describe Jeremy Lin for ESPN employees and the consequences of visually comparing Douglas to a monkey (for which NBC apologized but no suspension or termination of any personnel was reported) demonstrates what van Leeuwen (2000) observed: “Visually communicated racism can be much more easily denied, much more easily dismissed as ‘in the eye of the beholder’ than verbal

racism” (p. 335). Thus, Cheng-Chu's own discussion in the ensemble serves as an effective starting point from which she could further examine the ways in which ideologies are realized through different modes.

Teachers can also help students work on how to effectively express in language what they successfully expressed visually. For example, students could be asked to write a traditional report on the contents of their multimodal ensembles. Using multimodality as the basis for English language development is an important aspect of multimodal pedagogy for language learners because the linguistic mode is still the dominant mode through which their English proficiency is assessed. Incorporating multimodality in the second and foreign language classrooms need not marginalize the linguistic mode, a concern voiced by teachers (Yi & Choi, 2015) and raised by Qu (2017), but can serve as an opportunity to enhance learners' critical examination of sociopolitical issues in the target language.

7 | THE AUTHOR

Shin-ying Huang is an associate professor in the Department of Foreign Languages and Literatures at National Taiwan University in Taiwan. Her research interests include critical literacies, multimodal pedagogies, and critical multimodal discourse analysis. She has published in journals such as *English Teaching: Practice and Critique*, *Gender and Education*, *Journal of Adolescent and Adult Literacy*, *Language Learning and Technology*, *Language, Culture and Curriculum*, and *English Teaching and Learning*, among others.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This research received funding support from the Ministry of Science and Technology of Taiwan (MOST 103-2410-H-002-233).

REFERENCES

- Albers, P. (2011). Double exposure: A critical study of preservice teachers' multimodal public service announcements. *Multimodal Communication*, 1(1), 47–64. <https://doi.org/10.1515/mc-2012-0005>
- Albers, P. (2014). Digital writing and the role of critical pedagogy in preservice teacher education. In R. E. Ferdig & K. E. Pytash (Eds.), *Exploring multimodal composition and digital writing* (pp. 98–115). Hershey, PA: IGI Global.
- Ates, B., Eslami, Z. R., & Wright, K. L. (2015). Incorporating world Englishes into undergraduate ESL education courses. *World Englishes*, 34, 485–501. <https://doi.org/10.1111/weng.12149>
- Baldry, A., & Thibault, P. J. (2006). *Multimodal transcription and text analysis*. London, England: Equinox.
- Carr, N. (2008). Is Google making us stupid? What the Internet is doing to our brains. *The Atlantic*, July/August. Retrieved from <http://www.theatlantic.com/>
- Chan, J. Y. H. (2016). A multi-perspective investigation of attitudes towards English accents in Hong Kong: Implications for pronunciation teaching. *TESOL Quarterly*, 50, 285–313. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesq.218>
- Chang, Y. J. (2014). Learning English today: What can World Englishes teach college students in Taiwan? *English Today*, 30(1), 21–27. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0266078413000527>
- Chun, C. W. (2012). The multimodalities of globalization: Teaching a YouTube video in an EAP classroom. *Research in the Teaching of English*, 47(2), 145–170.
- Chun, C. W. (2016). Addressing racialized multicultural discourses in an EAP textbook: Working toward a critical pedagogy approach. *TESOL Quarterly*, 50, 109–131. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesq.216>
- Columbus, C., Barnathan, M., Green, B. (Producers), & Taylor, T. (Director). (2011). *The help* [Motion Picture]. Los Angeles, CA: Walt Disney Studios.

- Curwood, J. S., & Gibbons, D. (2010). "Just like I have felt": Multimodal counternarratives in youth-produced digital media. *International Journal of Learning and Media*, 1(4), 59–77. https://doi.org/10.1162/ijlm_a_00034
- Denzin, N. K., & Lincoln, Y. S. (Eds.). (2011). *The SAGE handbook of qualitative research*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Early, M., Kendrick, M., & Potts, D. (Eds.). (2015). Multimodality: Out from the margins of English language teaching [Special issue]. *TESOL Quarterly*, 49, 447–622. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesq.246>
- Erling, E. J. (2007). Local identities, global connections: Affinities to English among students at the Freie Universitat Berlin. *World Englishes*, 26, 111–130. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-971X.2007.00497.x>
- Goldsmith-Thomas, E., Schiff, P., Schindler, D. (Producers), & Wang, W. (Director). (2002). *Maid in Manhattan* [Motion Picture]. Los Angeles, CA: Columbia Pictures.
- Hafner, C. A. (2014). Embedding digital literacies in English language teaching: Students' digital video projects as multimodal ensembles. *TESOL Quarterly*, 48, 655–685. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesq.138>
- Hafner, C. A. (2015). Remix culture and English language teaching: The expression of learner voice in digital multimodal compositions. *TESOL Quarterly*, 49, 486–509. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesq.238>
- Hammond, K. (2006). More than a game: A critical discourse analysis of a racial inequality exercise in Japan. *TESOL Quarterly*, 40, 545–571. <https://doi.org/10.2307/40264543>
- Huang, S.y. (2015). The intersection of multimodality and critical perspective: Multimodality as subversion. *Language Learning and Technology*, 19(3), 21–37.
- Hull, G. A., & Nelson, M. E. (2005). Locating the semiotic power of multimodality. *Written Communication*, 22(2), 224–261. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0741088304274170>
- Hunter, J., Hunter, M. (Writers), & Lazarus, P. (Director). (2010). *Foreign exchange* [Television series episode]. In W. Walian, V. Patel R. Brown, & R. Shorr (Producers), *The Middle*. Burbank, CA: Warner Bros. Television.
- Janks, H. (2008). Teaching language and power. In S. May, & N. H. Hornberger (Eds.), *Encyclopedia of language and education* (2nd ed.), Vol. 1: Language policy and political issues in education (pp. 183–193). New York, NY: Springer. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-0-387-30424-3>
- Jenkins, J. (2007). *English as a lingua franca: Attitude and identity*. Oxford, England: Oxford University Press.
- Kanno, Y., & Vandrick, S. (Eds.). (2014). Social class in language learning and teaching. [Special issue]. *Journal of Language, Identity, and Education*, 13(2), 85–123. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15348458.2014.901819>
- Khan, N. (Writer), & Shelton, J. (Director). (2015). *Pilot* [Television series episode]. In R. Blomquist, E. Huang, & J. McEwen (Producers), *Fresh off the boat*. Los Angeles, CA: 20th Century Fox Television.
- Knobel, M., & Lankshear, C. (2008). Remix: The art and craft of endless hybridization. *Journal of Adolescent and Adult Literacy*, 52(1), 22–33. <https://doi.org/10.1598/JAAL.52.1.3>
- Kress, G. (2003). *Literacy in the new media age*. New York, NY: Routledge.
- Kress, G., & van Leeuwen, T. (2006). *Reading images: The grammar of visual design* (2nd ed.). New York, NY: Routledge.
- Kubota, R., & Miller, E. R. (2017). Re-examining and re-envisioning criticality in language studies: Theories and praxis. *Critical Inquiry in Language Studies*, 14, 129–157. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15427587.2017.1290500>
- Kumaravadivelu, B. (2006a). TESOL methods: Changing tracks, challenging trends. *TESOL Quarterly*, 40, 59–81. <https://doi.org/10.2307/40264511>
- Kumaravadivelu, B. (2006b). Dangerous liaison: Globalization, empire and TESOL. In J. Edge (Ed.), *(Re-)locating TESOL in an age of empire* (pp. 1–26). New York, NY: Palgrave.
- Lewis, C., & Ketter, J. (2004). Learning as social interaction: Interdiscursivity in a teacher and researcher study group. In R. Rogers (Ed.), *An introduction to critical discourse analysis in education* (pp. 117–146). Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum.
- Machin, D., Caldas-Coulthard, C. R., & Milani, M. (2016). Doing critical multimodality in research on gender, language and discourse. *Gender and Language*, 10, 301–308. <https://doi.org/10.1558/genl.v10i3.32037>
- Mahiri, J. (2006). Digital DJ-ing: Rhythms of learning in an urban school. *Language Arts*, 84(1), 55–62. <https://doi.org/10.3998/toi.10329379.0001.001>
- Matsuda, A. (2003). The ownership of English in Japanese secondary schools. *World Englishes*, 22, 483–496. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-971X.2003.00314.x>
- Mauranen, A. (2012). *Exploring ELF: Academic English shaped by non-native speakers*. Cambridge, England: Cambridge University Press.
- Mavers, D. (2012). Transcribing video. *MODE Working Papers*. Retrieved http://eprints.ncrm.ac.uk/2877/4/NCRM_working_paper0512.pdf

- Mayr, A., & Machin, D. (2012). *How to do critical discourse analysis: A multimodal introduction*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Morgan, B. (1997). Identity and intonation: Linking dynamic process in an ESL classroom. *TESOL Quarterly*, 31, 431–450. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3587833>
- Motha, S. (2006a). Decolonizing ESOL: Negotiating linguistic power in U.S. public school classrooms. *Critical Inquiry in Language Studies*, 3(2&3), 75–100. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15427587.2006.9650841>
- Motha, S. (2006b). Racializing ESOL teacher identities in U.S. K–12 public schools. *TESOL Quarterly*, 40, 495–518. <https://doi.org/10.2307/40264541>
- NBC forced to apologize. (2012, August 4). Daily Mail. Retrieved from <http://www.dailymail.co.uk/>
- Nelson, C. (2004). Beyond straight grammar: Using lesbian/gay themes to explore cultural meanings. In B. Norton & A. Pavlenko (Eds.), *Gender and English language learners* (pp. 15–28). Alexandria, VA: TESOL.
- Nelson, M. E. (2008). Multimodal synthesis and the voice of the multimedia author in a Japanese EFL context. *Innovations in Language Learning and Teaching*, 2(1), 65–82. <https://doi.org/10.2167/illt057.0>
- Nelson, M. E., & Johnson, N. H. (2014). The shape of joy, the colour of fear: Multimodal abduction in the foreign language classroom. *Pedagogies: An International Journal*, 9(1), 45–62. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1554480X.2014.877556>
- Qu, W. (2017). For L2 writers, it is always the problem of language. *Journal of Second Language Writing*, 38, 92–93. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jslw.2017.10.007>
- Richards, K. (2003). *Qualitative inquiry in TESOL*. Basingstoke, England: Macmillan. <https://doi.org/10.1057/9780230505056>
- Rose, D. (2000). Analysis of moving images. In M. W. Bauer & G. Gaskell (Eds.), *Qualitative researching with text, image and sound* (pp. 246–262). Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Schmier, S. A. (2013). Designing space for student choice in a digital media studies classroom. In J. Avila & J. Z. Pandya (Eds.), *Critical digital literacies as social praxis: Intersections and challenges* (pp. 15–39). New York, NY: Peter Lang.
- Shen, F. (1989). The classroom and the wider culture: Identity as a key to learning English composition. *College Composition and Communication*, 40, 459–466. <https://doi.org/10.2307/358245>
- Shin, D. S., & Cimasko, T. (2008). Multimodal composition in a college ESL class: New tools, traditional norms. *Computers and Composition*, 25, 376–395. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.compcom.2008.07.001>
- Silver, J., Van Wyck, J. (Producers), & Bartkowiak, A. (Director). (2000). *Romeo must die* [Motion Picture]. Burbank, CA: Warner Bros. Entertainment.
- Stein, P. (2008). *Multimodal pedagogies in diverse classrooms: Representation, rights and resources*. New York, NY: Routledge.
- Tan, A. (1990). Mother tongue. *Threepenny Review*, 43, 7–8.
- Taylor, L. (2006). Wrestling with race: The implications of integrative antiracism education for immigrant ESL youth. *TESOL Quarterly*, 40, 519–544. <https://doi.org/10.2307/40264542>
- van Leeuwen, T. (2000). Visual racism. In M. Reisigl & R. Wodak (Eds.), *The semiotics of racism: Approaches in critical discourse analysis*. (pp. 333–350) Vienna, Austria: Passagen Verlag.
- Vandrick, S. (2011). Students of the new global elite. *TESOL Quarterly*, 45, 160–169. <https://doi.org/10.5054/tq.2011.244020>
- Yang, J. (2015, February 6). For a dad stung by stereotypes, “Fresh Off the Boat” is point of pride. *Los Angeles Times*. Retrieved from <http://www.latimes.com/>
- Yang, Y. F. (2012). Multimodal composing in digital storytelling. *Computers and Composition*, 29, 221–238. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.compcom.2012.07.001>
- Yi, Y., & Choi, J. (2015). Teachers’ views of multimodal practices in K–12 classrooms: Voices from teachers in the United States. *TESOL Quarterly*, 49, 838–847. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesq.219>
- Yoshikawa, H. (2005). Recognition of world Englishes: Changes in Chukyo University students’ attitudes. *World Englishes*, 24, 351–360. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.0083-2919.2005.00416.x>

How to cite this article: Huang S-y. EFL learners’ critical multimodal reflections on the politics of English. *TESOL J.* 2019;10:e435. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesj.435>